

suites, at least the same number of concertos, 50 sonatas, 40 quartets, a mountain of chamber music, and about 250 pieces for solo keyboard. He harmonized 500 hymns and published several dozen songs. Yet Telemann was celebrated not for the quantity but for the quality of his work, for his innovation and invention, his genius for combining diverse musical styles, and his ability to keep pace with changing tastes.

A secret passion

Telemann was born in Magdeburg (see [box](#)) in 1681. His father died soon after his birth. Although the young Georg received singing lessons and basic keyboard training, he was essentially a self-taught musician and composer. His mother disapproved of his passion for music, and confiscated all his instruments; like Handel, who was 50 miles (80 km) south in Halle, he practiced and composed in secret.

Family pressure and personal ambition nudged Telemann to study law at Leipzig University. After his setting of Psalm 6 was performed at St. Thomas's, Leipzig's mayor invited him to write works for St. Thomas's and for New Church. Telemann formed a student band soon after, became musical director of Leipzig's opera and organist of New Church, and fell out with the envious Johann Kuhnau, St. Thomas's overworked cantor.

During his Leipzig apprenticeship and later in service to the Count of Promnitz, Telemann mastered the major European musical styles while absorbing Polish and Moravian folk music. He took jobs in Eisenach, Bach's hometown, and in Frankfurt, where he made a rich living as city director of music and church